

In-Class Discussion

EN 601.124: The Ethics of Artificial Intelligence and Automation

Department of Computer Science, March 25th 2026





Winner, Langdon. "Do artifacts have politics?." Computer ethics. Routledge, 1980. 177-192.

1. What counts as an artifact? Winner's examples are mostly physical infrastructure. Does his argument extend cleanly to AI artifacts (if, so, what are they)? Where does the metaphor break when it comes to AI?



**Jacobs, Abigail Z., and Hanna Wallach.
"Measurement and fairness." Proceedings of
the 2021 ACM conference on fairness,
accountability, and transparency. 2021.**

**2. In your own words, what is the difference
between a construct, a measurement, and
an operationalization as Jacobs & Wallach
use these terms? Why does that distinction
matter for evaluating claims about
algorithmic fairness?**



3. Jacobs & Wallach argue that many fairness metrics measure proxies for the construct of interest rather than the construct itself. What's an example from your own knowledge (outside of the paper and past readings or lectures) where this gap between proxy and construct is especially consequential?



Raji, Inioluwa Deborah, et al. "Closing the AI accountability gap: Defining an end-to-end framework for internal algorithmic auditing." Proceedings of the 2020 conference on fairness, accountability, and transparency. 2020.

4. Walk through the five stages Raji et al. propose. Which stage do you think is most commonly skipped in practice?



5. Raji et al. explicitly focus on internal auditing rather than external or regulatory auditing. What justification do they give for this focus? Do you find it convincing?



All three readings engage — to varying degrees — with the question of whether technical methods can solve what may be social or political problems. Winner is most skeptical; Raji et al. are most optimistic about technical process; Jacobs & Wallach occupy a middle position. Where do you land?